exness_bot — Step-by-Step Guide

LLM + rule-based auto-trading bot for Exness (MetaTrader 5)

Version 1.2 · Author: Waleed Hassan · Runs on Windows 7, 10 and 11

> **Read this first.** Automated FX/CFD trading loses money for most retail traders. **No bot can guarantee profit or "no losses" — this one cannot either.** The conservative defaults (small size, 2%/day loss cap, 10% total-loss kill switch, DRY-RUN, demo lock) keep a bad run *small*; they do not make it profitable. This bot is a **framework and starting point** and has **not** been run against a live account by the author. Always go **backtest → demo for weeks → tiny live size**, in that order. Algo trading is allowed by Exness; arbitrage, latency exploitation and quote-delay tick-scalping are not. Nothing here is financial advice.

Requirements (full list)

To backtest only (any OS, no broker needed)

Need	Detail
Operating system	Windows, macOS or Linux
Python	3.8–3.12, **64-bit** (tick *Add Python to PATH*)
Python packages	`pandas`, `numpy` — `pip install pandas` pulls both
Data	one CSV of candles, columns `time,open,high,low,close`

To trade (demo or live)

Need	Detail
Operating system	**Windows 7 SP1 / 10 / 11, 64-bit.** The `MetaTrader5` package is Windows-only; a Windows VPS also counts.
Python	**Windows 7 → Python 3.8.10** (last version that installs on Win 7). **Windows 10 / 11 → latest Python 3.** 64-bit, *Add Python to PATH*.
Python packages	`MetaTrader5>=5.0.37`, `pandas>=1.3.5`, `numpy>=1.21`; plus `openai>=1.10,<2` only for LLM mode. All installed by `pip install -r requirements.txt`.
Broker terminal	**Exness MetaTrader 5** desktop terminal, installed and logged in.
Exness account	Start with a **demo** account — you need its *login number*, *password* and *server* (e.g. `Exness-MT5Trial`).
Terminal setting	**Tools → Options → Expert Advisors → Allow algorithmic trading** ticked.
Network / uptime	Stable internet; the PC or VPS stays on and the terminal stays open while the bot runs.
Disk / RAM	~1 GB free disk (Python + MT5), 2 GB+ RAM.
Optional	An **OpenAI API key** — only if `USE_LLM = True` and you want LLM decisions instead of the built-in rules.

Hardware needs are light: the bot polls every few seconds and holds one position at a time. Any machine that runs the MT5 terminal comfortably runs the bot.

Part A — The easy way (no coding needed)

If you are not a programmer, follow just this part. You need a **Windows PC** (7, 10 or 11), a **free Exness demo account**, and about **20 minutes**. You will not type any code — only double-click a few files and fill in one form.

1. **Step 1 — Install Python (one time)**

   Go to `python.org/downloads`.
   - **Windows 7:** download **Python 3.8.10** (page: `python.org/downloads/release/python-3810/` → "Windows installer 64-bit"). Newer Python versions do *not* install on Windows 7.
   - **Windows 10 / 11:** download the latest Python 3.

   Run the installer.
   Tick the box "Add Python to PATH"
   , then click *Install Now*.

2. **Step 2 — Download the bot**

   Open `github.com/waleed260/exness-bot`. Click the green
   Code
   button →
   Download ZIP
   . Right-click the downloaded ZIP → *Extract All*. Remember where the folder is (e.g. your Desktop).

3. **Step 3 — Install MetaTrader 5 from Exness**

   In your Exness Personal Area, create a
   demo
   account and note its *login number*, *password* and *server* (e.g. `Exness-MT5Trial`). Download and install the
   Exness MetaTrader 5
   terminal and log into that demo account. In MT5:
   Tools → Options → Expert Advisors
   → tick
   "Allow algorithmic trading"
   → OK.

4. **Step 4 — Set it up (one time)**

   Open the extracted bot folder. Double-click
   `install.bat`
   . A black window installs everything (a few minutes), then a small text file opens in Notepad. Fill in your demo *login number*, *password* and *server* between the quote marks, then
   Save

(`Ctrl`+`S`) and close Notepad.

If it says "Python is not installed", you missed the "Add Python to PATH" tick in Step 1 — re-run the Python installer and choose *Modify*.

5. **Step 5 — Run it**

   Double-click `run.bat`. A black window opens and starts printing what the bot is doing. It is in **safe DRY-RUN mode**: it makes decisions and writes them down but **does not place any real orders**. Leave it running as long as you like.

   To stop: click the window and press `Ctrl`+`C`, or just close the window.

6. **Step 6 — See what it did**

   Inside the bot folder open `exness_bot\logs\`: `bot.log` is the full running commentary; `trades.csv` lists every trade it opened/closed (open it in Excel).

7. **Step 7 — Test on past data (optional but recommended)**

   In MetaTrader 5: *View → Symbols → Bars*, pick your pair and timeframe, *Export Bars* to a CSV file. Then double-click `backtest.bat` and drag that CSV into the window. It prints whether the strategy would have made or lost money, and a plain **EDGE / NO EDGE** verdict.

8. **Step 8 — Only when you are ready for more**

   - *Trade the demo for real* (still fake money): open `exness_bot\config.py` in Notepad, find `DRY_RUN = True`, change it to `DRY_RUN = False`, save. Run `run.bat` again.
   - *Real money:* only after several weeks of good demo results. See Part 6. Start with the smallest possible size.

> **Golden rules.** 1) Never skip the demo stage. 2) Never use money you cannot afford to lose. 3) The built-in strategy is a *starting point*, not a money machine — prove it with the backtester and the demo first.

The rest of this document (Parts 1–12) is the detailed reference: what each part does, every setting, command-line usage, an honest assessment for Exness, and troubleshooting.

1. What the bot does

> **Safe development status.** The default execution mode is `simulation` with `DRY_RUN=True`. The local simulator can open, monitor, apply SL/TP, close, persist, and recover test positions without an MT5 account. Live automatic trading is disabled by `LIVE_TRADING_ENABLED=False`. Creating `exness_bot/STOP_TRADING` blocks all new entries.

Once per **closed candle** (default timeframe M15) it runs this pipeline:

```
MT5 price history
      ▼
indicators   SMA(20), SMA(50), RSI(14), ATR(14), 200-SMA trend
      ▼
strategy     LLM decision (OpenAI)  --falls back to-->  rule set
      ▼                                    (SMA crossover + RSI + trend)
decision     buy / sell / close / hold   (+ confidence 0..1)
      ▼
filters      session window? spread ok? min ATR? confidence >= min?
             daily loss limit not hit? no position already open?
      ▼
risk         lot size from RISK_PER_TRADE_PCT
             SL = SL_ATR_MULT x ATR,  TP = TP_ATR_MULT x ATR
      ▼
executor     mt5.order_send (retries on requote)   [skipped if DRY_RUN]
```

On **every poll** (default every 5 s) it also manages any open position:

- at **+1.0R** profit → move the stop loss to entry (break-even);
- at **+1.5R** profit → trail the stop `2 × ATR` behind price;
- the stop is only ever tightened, never loosened.

`R` = the initial risk distance (entry → stop loss). All activity is logged to `exness_bot/logs/bot.log`; each entry/exit is appended to `exness_bot/logs/trades.csv`.

2. What every file is for

File	Job
`exness_bot/config.py`	all settings. `DRY_RUN=True`, `DEMO_ONLY=True` by default
`exness_bot/settings.example.py`	copy to `settings.py`; MT5 login + optional OpenAI key (git-ignored)
`exness_bot/mt5_client.py`	connect, account, positions, candles; auto-resolves the broker symbol suffix; reports spread
`exness_bot/indicators.py`	indicator maths + trailing-stop + session logic. No MT5 import, so the backtester reuses it
`exness_bot/data.py`	pulls live candles → DataFrame with indicator columns; drops the still-forming candle
`exness_bot/strategy.py`	picks a prompt, applies the cost guardrails, calls the LLM, validates the JSON; rule-based fallback
`exness_bot/prompts.py`	five named LLM prompt presets; `config.LLM_PROMPT_NAME` chooses one
`exness_bot/llm_guard.py`	keeps OpenAI spend low: only-on-signal, per-day cap, daily $ limit, min gap, snapshot cache, spend estimate
`exness_bot/risk.py`	lot sizing, SL/TP, break-even + trailing stop, daily-loss guard, session check
`exness_bot/executor.py`	`mt5.order_send` for open / close / modify-stop, with retries; obeys `DRY_RUN`
`exness_bot/runner.py`	the main loop that ties it together
`exness_bot/backtest.py`	runs the rule strategy over history and prints edge metrics
`install.bat` / `run.bat` / `backtest.bat`	Windows double-click helpers (Part A) — they just call the commands below for you

3. Every setting in `config.py`

Safety

Setting	Default	Meaning
`DRY_RUN`	`True`	`True` = never send a real order, only log what it would do
`DEMO_ONLY`	`True`	refuse to start if the connected account is a live account
`CONFIRM_LIVE_STRING`	`""`	must equal `"I ACCEPT THE RISK"` to run on a live account
`EXECUTION_MODE`	`"simulation"`	`simulation`, `demo`, or `live`; simulation is the default
`LIVE_TRADING_ENABLED`	`False`	hard gate; remains disabled during development
`EMERGENCY_STOP_FILE`	`exness_bot/STOP_TRADING`	presence blocks new entries
`MAX_TRADES_PER_DAY`	`10`	daily entry limit
`MAX_CONSECUTIVE_LOSSES`	`3`	blocks new entries after consecutive losses
`MAX_DATA_AGE_SECONDS`	`7200`	rejects stale candles before analysis

Market

Setting	Default	Meaning
`SYMBOL`	`EURUSD`	base name; broker suffix (`m` , `.` , `z` …) found automatically
`TIMEFRAME`	`M15`	candle used for decisions
`LOOKBACK_BARS`	`400`	candles pulled for indicators / LLM context

Risk

Defaults are deliberately conservative — they cap the damage of a bad run, they do **not** guarantee a profit.

Setting	Default	Meaning
`RISK_PER_TRADE_PCT`	`0.25`	percent of balance lost if the stop is hit
`FIXED_LOT_FALLBACK`	`0.01`	lot used if sizing can't be computed (also clamped to `MAX_LOT`)
`MAX_LOT`	`0.05`	hard cap on lot size
`MAX_OPEN_POSITIONS`	`1`	positions allowed at once on this symbol
`ATR_PERIOD`	`14`	ATR length
`SL_ATR_MULT`	`2.0`	stop distance = this × ATR
`TP_ATR_MULT`	`3.0`	target distance = this × ATR
`MIN_ATR_POINTS`	`0`	skip entries when ATR (points) is below this; `0` = off
`DAILY_MAX_LOSS_PCT`	`2.0`	stop opening trades for the day after this equity drawdown
`MAX_TOTAL_LOSS_PCT`	`10.0`	**hard kill switch** — stop the bot for good if equity falls this far below the equity it launched with; `0` = off
`MIN_CONFIDENCE`	`0.55`	ignore buy/sell signals weaker than this

Trailing / break-even

Setting	Default	Meaning
`BREAKEVEN_AT_R`	`1.0`	move stop to entry once profit reaches this many R; `0` = off
`TRAIL_AT_R`	`1.5`	start trailing once profit reaches this many R; `0` = off
`TRAIL_ATR_MULT`	`2.0`	trailing stop sits this × ATR behind price

Entry filters

Setting	Default	Meaning
`MAX_SPREAD_POINTS`	`25`	skip entries when the spread is wider than this
`USE_TREND_FILTER`	`True`	only long in an up-trend, only short in a down-trend
`TREND_SMA`	`200`	SMA used as the trend proxy
`TREND_SLOPE_LOOKBACK`	`20`	bars back used to measure the trend SMA slope
`SESSION_UTC_HOURS`	`[7, 16]`	trade only between these UTC hours; `[]` = always
`TRADE_DAYS`	`[0,1,2,3,4]`	weekdays allowed (Mon–Fri)

Execution

Setting	Default	Meaning
`DEVIATION_POINTS`	`20`	maximum slippage accepted, in points
`MAGIC`	`20240601`	id stamped on this bot's orders
`POLL_SECONDS`	`5`	how often the loop checks for a new candle / manages the stop
`ORDER_RETRIES`	`3`	retries on requote / price-changed
`TRADE_LOG_CSV`	`exness_bot/logs/trades.csv`	where trades are recorded

Strategy

Setting	Default	Meaning
`USE_LLM`	`True`	use the LLM if an API key is set, else the rule set
`SMA_FAST` / `SMA_SLOW`	`20` / `50`	crossover SMAs
`RSI_PERIOD`	`14`	RSI length

LLM cost guardrails

Only apply when `USE_LLM=True` **and** `settings.OPENAI_API_KEY` is set. Full walkthrough in Part 7.

Setting	Default	Meaning
`LLM_PROMPT_NAME`	`"conservative"`	preset from `prompts.py`: `conservative` / `trend_follow` / `mean_reversion` / `breakout` / `swing`
`LLM_ONLY_ON_SIGNAL`	`True`	call the model **only** when the rule engine already sees a buy/sell/close setup — the biggest cost saver
`LLM_ENTRIES_ONLY`	`True`	never spend a call on an exit — rules + SL/TP + trailing stop close positions; only entries go to the model
`LLM_MIN_SECONDS_BETWEEN_CALLS`	`300`	hard floor on call frequency, whatever the timeframe
`LLM_MAX_CALLS_PER_DAY`	`20`	hard cap per UTC day; `0` = unlimited
`LLM_DAILY_COST_LIMIT_USD`	`0.15`	stop calling once the day's *estimated* spend hits this; `0` = off
`LLM_SKIP_OUTSIDE_SESSION`	`True`	no calls outside `SESSION_UTC_HOURS` / `TRADE_DAYS`
`LLM_CACHE_SNAPSHOT`	`True`	reuse the last decision when the snapshot barely moved (no call)
`LLM_SEND_PRICE_HISTORY`	`False`	include `last_10_closes` in the prompt (more tokens; rarely worth it)
`LLM_MAX_OUTPUT_TOKENS`	`40`	reply is a tiny JSON object; capped low
`LLM_COST_PER_1K_INPUT` / `_OUTPUT`	`0.00015` / `0.0006`	fallback price for the log estimate; a known `OPENAI_MODEL` uses its own price automatically

Backtest

Setting	Default	Meaning
`BT_SPREAD_POINTS`	`12`	spread cost (points) charged on every backtested trade
`BT_COMMISSION_PER_LOT`	`7.0`	informational commission assumption for Raw/Zero accounts
`BT_START_BALANCE`	`1000`	starting balance for the money curve

4. Step-by-step: backtest (do this FIRST)

Why first: the backtest tells you whether the strategy has any edge on past data *before* you risk a cent. If it says NO EDGE, do not run it on demo or live — change the settings and test again. Runs on **any OS** (Windows / macOS / Linux) — no MetaTrader, no broker needed.

Step 1 — install Python + pandas

In the VS Code terminal (or any terminal), from the `exness-bot` folder:

```
pip install pandas
```

That also pulls `numpy`. You do **not** need `MetaTrader5` for a CSV backtest.

Step 2 — get historical candles as a CSV

One CSV with columns `time, open, high, low, close` (extra columns are ignored; headers like `<OPEN>` / `Date` are auto-mapped).

From the Exness MT5 terminal (best):

1. MT5 → **View** → **Symbols** (or `Ctrl`+`U`).
2. Pick your pair (e.g. `EURUSD`) → tab **Bars**.
3. **Timeframe = M15** (match `config.TIMEFRAME`), pick a wide date range (2+ years), click **Request** then **Export Bars** → save as `EURUSD_M15.csv`.
4. Make a `data` folder inside `exness-bot`, move the file to `data/EURUSD_M15.csv`.

Or a free source: any OHLC-candle provider (Dukascopy, HistData, TraderMade…). Save it with those column names.

Step 3 — run the backtest

```
python -m exness_bot.backtest --csv data/EURUSD_M15.csv
```

On Windows with the MT5 terminal open and `settings.py` filled in, you can skip the CSV and pull data straight from the broker:

```
python -m exness_bot.backtest --mt5 180        # last 180 days of config.TIMEFRAME
```

Step 4 — read the report

```
data span      : 2023-01-02 -> 2025-06-30 (910 days)
trades         : 148
win rate       : 41.9%
avg win / loss : +1.85R / -1.00R
expectancy     : +0.043R per trade
profit factor  : 1.21
total          : +6.4R
max drawdown   : 7.8%
balance        : 1000 -> 1187  (+19%)
verdict        : EDGE? maybe - forward test on demo
```

Result	Meaning
PASS	`expectancy > 0` *and* `profit factor > 1.15` *and* a believable trade count (say ≥ 100) → go to Part 5, forward-test on **demo**
FAIL	anything else, or `verdict : NO EDGE` → do **not** trade it; go to Step 5

Step 5 — if it fails, tune and re-run

Change **one thing at a time** in `exness_bot/config.py`, save, run Step 3 again, compare:

- `TIMEFRAME` (`_M5` / `_M15` / `_H1` …)
- `SMA_FAST` / `SMA_SLOW`, `RSI_PERIOD`
- `SL_ATR_MULT` / `TP_ATR_MULT`
- filters: `USE_TREND_FILTER`, `SESSION_UTC_HOURS`, `MIN_CONFIDENCE`

Per-trade detail for the last run is written to `exness_bot/logs/backtest_trades.csv` (open in Excel).

Step 6 — validate before trusting it

Even a PASS can be luck. Before demo:

- Re-run on a **different pair** (e.g. `GBPUSD`) — still positive?
- Tune on the first half of the data, then run **untouched** on the second half — still positive? (walk-forward)
- Only then move to Part 5.

> **Never** move to demo-real or live money on a “NO EDGE” result. The built-in SMA/RSI strategy is a starting point and usually shows no edge as-is.

5. Step-by-step: demo on Windows

The `MetaTrader5` Python package only runs on **Windows** (a Windows VPS is fine).

Python version: on **Windows 7** use **Python 3.8.10** — the last release that installs on Win 7, and `requirements.txt` is set so the right package versions install automatically. On **Windows 10 / 11** use the latest Python 3. Either way tick *"Add Python to PATH"* and use the **64-bit** installer.

1. Create a **demo** account in the Exness Personal Area; note the login number, password and server (e.g. `Exness-MT5Trial`).
2. Install the **Exness MetaTrader 5** terminal, log into the demo account.
3. In the terminal: **Tools → Options → Expert Advisors → Allow algorithmic trading** (tick it).
4. Install dependencies:

   ```
   pip install -r requirements.txt
   ```

5. Create your private config:

   ```
   copy exness_bot\settings.example.py exness_bot\settings.py
   ```

   Edit `exness_bot\settings.py`:

   ```
   MT5_PATH     = r"C:\Program Files\MetaTrader 5 EXNESS\terminal64.exe"
   MT5_LOGIN    = 12345678
   MT5_PASSWORD = "your-demo-password"
   MT5_SERVER   = "Exness-MT5Trial"
   OPENAI_API_KEY = ""          # leave empty to use the rule-based strategy
   OPENAI_MODEL   = "gpt-4o-mini"
   ```

   (`settings.py` is git-ignored — credentials never get committed.)
6. First run with `DRY_RUN = True` (the default):

   ```
   python -m exness_bot.runner
   ```

   Watch `exness_bot/logs/bot.log`. You'll see decisions and lines like `[DRY_RUN] would OPEN buy 0.02 EURUSD ...`. No orders are sent.
7. When the dry-run behaviour looks sane, set `DRY_RUN = False` in `exness_bot/config.py` and run again. Now it trades the **demo** account for real. Let it run for **several weeks**; review `logs/trades.csv`.

6. Step-by-step: going live (only after profitable demo)

1. In `exness_bot/config.py`:

```
DEMO_ONLY = False
CONFIRM_LIVE_STRING = "I ACCEPT THE RISK"
MAX_LOT = 0.01
RISK_PER_TRADE_PCT = 0.25      # start smaller than on demo
```

2. Put your **live** account details in `settings.py`.
3. Run `python -m exness_bot.runner`. It logs a warning that it is on a live account.
4. Watch it daily for the first weeks. Keep the daily loss limit tight.
5. Scale size up only after months of consistent results, never faster than your drawdown tolerance.

Keep the machine/VPS on and the MT5 terminal running. If the terminal closes, the bot loses its connection — open positions keep their broker-side SL/TP, but the trailing logic pauses until it reconnects.

7. LLM mode & keeping the OpenAI bill tiny

The bot runs fully **without** OpenAI — the rule engine is the default and costs **$0**. LLM mode adds a second opinion: on a *potential* trade it asks a model for a `buy / sell / close / hold` JSON decision, and still falls back to the rule result if anything goes wrong.

7.1 Add your API key (do it in VS Code)

1. **Create a key** at `platform.openai.com/api-keys`.
2. **Set a hard monthly spend limit and turn auto-recharge OFF** at `platform.openai.com/settings/organization/limits` (e.g. $5). This is the ceiling that actually protects you.
3. In VS Code open **`exness_bot/settings.py`** (the file you made from `settings.example.py`) and paste the key:

   ```
   OPENAI_API_KEY = "sk-...your key..."
   OPENAI_MODEL   = "gpt-4o-mini"
   ```

   Save. `settings.py` is git-ignored, so the key is never committed.
4. In `exness_bot/config.py` keep `USE_LLM = True`. The guardrails below are already switched on.

7.2 Which model handles trades best?

`gpt-4o-mini` is the default and is fine for this simple SMA/RSI strategy. For stronger judgement on messy / borderline setups, set a bigger model in `settings.py` — the guardrails keep even the big ones at cents per month.

OPENAI_MODEL	When to use it	~cost / decision
`gpt-4o-mini` (default)	simple strategy, tightest budget	~$0.00006
`gpt-4.1-mini`	a bit sharper, still very cheap	~$0.0002
`gpt-4o`	best at reading unclear / conflicting setups	~$0.001
`gpt-4.1`	strongest reasoning of the four	~$0.002

`llm_guard.py` knows these prices, so the spend line in the log stays accurate whichever you pick; a newer model id just falls back to the `LLM_COST_PER_1K_*` estimate.

7.3 What keeps the cost down

Every guardrail lives in the **LLM cost guardrails** block of `config.py` (table in Part 3). In plain terms:

- **Only on a signal.** `LLM_ONLY_ON_SIGNAL=True` — the model is called *only* when the free rule engine already sees a setup. Quiet candles cost nothing. This alone removes most calls.
- **Entries only.** `LLM_ENTRIES_ONLY=True` — the model is never asked about closing a trade; rules, the broker SL/TP and the trailing stop handle exits. Roughly halves what is left.

- **A hard daily budget.** `LLM_MAX_CALLS_PER_DAY=20` and `LLM_DAILY_COST_LIMIT_USD=0.15` — whichever is hit first, the bot goes rules-only for the rest of the UTC day.
- **A minimum gap.** `LLM_MIN_SECONDS_BETWEEN_CALLS=300` — at most one call per 5 minutes.
- **Session-aware.** `LLM_SKIP_OUTSIDE_SESSION=True` — no calls at night or on weekends.
- **Caching.** `LLM_CACHE_SNAPSHOT=True` — if the market barely moved, the previous answer is reused with no new call.
- **Small prompts.** A compact one-line snapshot, `last_10_closes` left out, reply capped at `LLM_MAX_OUTPUT_TOKENS=40`, and `response_format=json_object` so a reply is never wasted.

`logs/bot.log` prints a live estimate on every call:

```
LLM call 3/20 today | ~256 in / 20 out tok | est $0.00005 | est day total $0.0002
```

7.4 Rough cost

With `gpt-4o-mini`, one decision is about **$0.00006** (~260 input + 20 output tokens). Even flat-out at 20 calls/day that is **a few cents a month**; with *only-on-signal* + *entries-only* it is usually a handful of calls a day. With `gpt-4o` multiply by ~15 and it is still well under a dollar a month. Your dashboard limit from step 2 is the real cap.

7.5 Choosing a prompt

`exness_bot/prompts.py` ships five presets. Set the one you want in `config.py`: `LLM_PROMPT_NAME = "conservative"`.

Name	Style
`conservative` (default)	trend-aligned, textbook setups only, holds when unsure
`trend_follow`	rides the 200-SMA trend, lets winners run
`mean_reversion`	fades RSI extremes back toward the slow SMA
`breakout`	momentum breakouts on expanding ATR, in the trend direction
`swing`	rare, high-confluence entries; expects long holds

To write your own: add another template to `PRESETS` in `prompts.py` (keep `+ _CONTRACT` on the end so the JSON reply still parses), then point `LLM_PROMPT_NAME` at it.

8. Run it in VS Code (for developers)

1. **Install VS Code**
   and the
   Python extension
   (Microsoft).
2. **File → Open Folder…**
   and pick the extracted `exness-bot` folder.
3. **Terminal → New Terminal**
   to get a shell at the project root.
4. *(Recommended)* create a virtual environment so packages stay local:

   ```
   python -m venv .venv
   .venv\Scripts\activate          # Windows
   # source .venv/bin/activate     # macOS / Linux (backtest only)
   ```

   Then click the Python version in the status bar (bottom-right) and select the `.venv` interpreter.
5. Install packages:

   ```
   pip install -r requirements.txt      # trading  (Windows)
   pip install pandas                   # backtest only (any OS)
   ```

6. Create the settings file once:

   ```
   copy exness_bot\settings.example.py exness_bot\settings.py    # Windows
   ```

   Open `exness_bot/settings.py` and fill in the demo login / password / server. For LLM mode, paste `OPENAI_API_KEY` here too — see
   Part 7
   . Cost knobs and the prompt preset live in `exness_bot/config.py` (`LLM cost guardrails`).
7. Run from the VS Code terminal:
   - Backtest — `python -m exness_bot.backtest --csv data/EURUSD_M15.csv`
   - Bot (safe DRY-RUN) — `python -m exness_bot.runner`
   - Or open `exness_bot/runner.py` and press `F5` to run under the debugger (set breakpoints in `strategy.py` / `risk.py` to watch a decision form).
8. Stop the bot with `Ctrl`+`C` in the terminal.

Output goes to `exness_bot/logs/bot.log` and `exness_bot/logs/trades.csv` — open them in the editor while it runs.

9. Deploy — where to run it and how (easy way)

What "deploy" means here: the bot has to stay running, and the **Exness MT5 terminal has to stay open and logged in** next to it. There is no website to upload to. You just pick a Windows machine that is always on and start the bot on it.

Which machine?

Choice	Good for	Notes
Your own PC	trying it, demo weeks	free; the PC must stay on 24/5 and not sleep
A Windows VPS	real / unattended use	~$10–30/mo; always on; search "Windows VPS" or "Forex VPS"

macOS / Linux / phones / free cloud containers **cannot** run it — the `MetaTrader5` package needs a real Windows session. (Linux is fine for backtesting only.)

Easy way — your own PC

1. Finish Part A (or Part 8) so `run.bat` already works once.
2. *Settings → Power & sleep →* set **Sleep = Never** (turning the screen off is fine; sleep is not).
3. Open the **Exness MT5** terminal, log in, leave it open.
4. Double-click **`run.bat`**. Leave the black window open. Done.
5. Check `exness_bot\logs\bot.log` now and then.

Easy way — a Windows VPS (recommended once past demo)

1. Buy a small **Windows Server VPS** (2 vCPU / 4 GB RAM is plenty).
2. On your PC press `Win`+`R`, type `mstsc`, enter the VPS address / user / password to get its desktop.
3. On the VPS do the normal one-time setup: install **Python** (same version rule as Part 5), install the **Exness MT5** terminal and log in, tick *Allow algorithmic trading*.
4. Copy the `exness-bot` folder onto the VPS (drag-and-drop into the Remote Desktop window). Run **`install.bat`**, fill in `settings.py`.
5. Run **`run.bat`**. Now close the Remote Desktop window (do **not** "Sign out") — the bot and MT5 keep running on the VPS.
6. Reconnect with `mstsc` any time to check on it.

Make it restart itself (optional, for real use)

So it comes back after a crash or a VPS reboot:

- **MT5:** add the terminal to Windows startup so it launches on boot.
- **The bot:** install **NSSM** (free), then in a terminal:

```
nssm install exness-bot "C:\path\to\python.exe" -m exness_bot.runner
nssm set exness-bot AppDirectory "C:\path\to\exness-bot"
nssm start exness-bot
```

Windows now keeps the bot running and restarts it if it exits. Or use **Task Scheduler** → new task → *Run whether user is logged on or not* + *Restart on failure*.

Check `logs/bot.log` every day for the first week.

No cloud / Docker option. `MetaTrader5` needs a real Windows session with the terminal running, so a Linux container cannot trade. A Linux box is fine for backtesting only.

10. How good is it for Exness — honest assessment

a) Will it work *technically* on Exness?

Fairly likely after a short debugging pass on demo. Usual first-run snags:

Snag	Fix
wrong `MT5_SERVER` string	`initialize failed` → copy the exact server name from the terminal
symbol is `EURUSDm` / `EURUSD.z` on your account	handled automatically; check the log line `Resolved symbol EURUSD -> ...`
"AutoTrading disabled"	step 5.3 above
broker min stop distance > your ATR stop	the bot clamps it; on very tight timeframes SL/TP get pushed out — use a higher timeframe

Rough chance of a clean demo run within a day or two: **~85%**.

b) Will it make real profit?

The built-in strategy (SMA crossover + RSI + trend filter, or a generic LLM prompt) is a **baseline, not an edge**. After spread, swap and commission its expected value is around zero-to-negative. Realistic odds that this exact configuration is net-profitable over a year: **~10–15%**, in line with retail algo-trading outcomes generally.

What actually moves that number:

- A strategy with a tested statistical edge — validate with `backtest.py` over several years and multiple symbols, then walk-forward.
- Trading the right sessions / instruments for that edge.
- Costs: a low-spread account type; avoid holding across the 3-day swap.
- Risk discipline: small `RISK_PER_TRADE_PCT`, a hard daily stop — which this bot already enforces.

> **Bottom line:** treat this as a solid *execution and risk* framework with a *backtester* attached. The profitable idea has to be yours and has to survive the backtest before any money is at stake.

11. Troubleshooting

Symptom	Cause / fix
`settings.py not found`	you didn't copy `settings.example.py` → `settings.py`
`mt5.initialize failed`	wrong `MT5_PATH`, `MT5_SERVER`, login or password; terminal not installed
`Symbol EURUSD(+suffix) not found`	your account uses a different name; add its suffix to `_SUFFIXES` in `mt5_client.py`
Decisions logged but no external orders	Expected in `simulation` mode or when `DRY_RUN` is `True`
`OPEN rejected: retcode=10027`	AutoTrading disabled in the terminal
`OPEN rejected: retcode=10016`	invalid stops (broker min distance); raise `SL_ATR_MULT` or use a higher timeframe
`OPEN rejected: retcode=10019`	not enough money for that lot; lower `RISK_PER_TRADE_PCT` or `MAX_LOT`
No trades ever	trend filter + session window too strict, or `MIN_CONFIDENCE` too high; loosen and re-backtest
LLM errors in the log	bad/empty `OPENAI_API_KEY`; the bot auto-falls back to the rule set
Log always says `Skipping LLM (...)`	that's the guardrails working — it calls the model only on a rule-side setup, within budget and session. Loosen the `LLM_*` settings in `config.py` for more calls (costs more).
`insufficient_quota` / `429` from OpenAI	add credit, or the dashboard spend limit is hit; the bot keeps trading rules-only meanwhile
Want $0 / no OpenAI at all	leave `OPENAI_API_KEY = ""` (or set `USE_LLM = False`) — pure rule engine
`OPEN rejected: retcode=10030` (Unsupported filling)	the bot now auto-retries FOK → IOC → RETURN; if it still fails, your account blocks market orders on that symbol
Bot exits with `MAX_TOTAL_LOSS_PCT hit`	equity fell 10% below launch — that's the kill switch. Review before restarting; adjust the % in `config.py`
Trade in the log but not in `trades.csv`	the order was rejected — a rejection is logged as an error and no longer written as a fake fill
`ModuleNotFoundError: MetaTrader5` on Win 10/11	you installed 32-bit Python, or Python is too new for a wheel — use the 64-bit installer and re-run `install.bat`
Python installer says "not supported on this OS" (Win 7)	you downloaded a version newer than 3.8.10 — get Python 3.8.10

12. Safe-launch checklist

[ ] Backtested on ≥ 2 years of data, on ≥ 2 symbols → positive expectancy, PF > 1.15

[ ] Walk-forward / out-of-sample check also positive

[ ] Ran on demo with `DRY_RUN=True`, decisions look sane in the log

[ ] Ran on demo with `DRY_RUN=False` for ≥ 4 weeks → result matches the backtest

[ ] `RISK_PER_TRADE_PCT` ≤ 0.25, `DAILY_MAX_LOSS_PCT` ≤ 2, `MAX_LOT` small

[ ] `MAX_TOTAL_LOSS_PCT` set to a number you would actually accept losing

[ ] Account type has low spread; you understand swap on your instrument

[ ] VPS / machine stays on; MT5 terminal set to start with the OS

[ ] You can afford to lose the whole account balance

Only when every box is ticked: set the two live flags and start at `0.01` lots.